frontier. Forming British India's centre was the administered frontier with defined bureaucratic mechanisms and linear boundaries; the 'inner ring' that included the NWFP, Balochistan, Kashmir, Nepal, and the Naga Hills; and the 'outer ring' that constituted Afghanistan, Persia (now Iran), Tibet, Burma (now Myanmar), Sinkiang (now Xinjiang), and Siam (now Thailand).[17] This dual-layered territorial defence system formed the backbone of colonial (and independent) India's regional strategic outlook. Management of this defence system elicited vibrant policy debates between what historians term the 'forward school' and the 'closed border school'. Though emerging in the 1820s and 1830s following disagreements between the administrations in Bombay and Ludhiana over the East India Company's approach towards the frontier regions, proponents of closed border school advocated non-interference in domestic Afghan affairs, preconditioned on Russia's non-interference in Afghanistan. Forward school proponents, however, derided this approach as 'masterly inactivity' and argued that only building military outworks in Kabul and Kandahar could stem a Russian advance. This required British India to get involved in domestic Afghan affairs. Independent India and Pakistan, to varying degrees, not only inherited this territorial construct but also the problems of governance associated with it (from Balochistan to Kashmir), as well as colonial strategic outlook embodied in these strategy-making debates. Though the impact of British bureaucratic and strategic culture on modern Indian thought is debatable, it has been difficult for Indian planners to move past South Asia's geopolitical history.

Partition of India in 1947 challenged the dual-layered defence strategy. Cutting right through the middle of what was considered India's 'center', the partition ruptured the innermost administrative frontier of the erstwhile Raj. Pakistan, and not Afghanistan, now dominated the minds of Indian strategists. Not surprisingly, the Treaty of Peace and Friendship between Afghanistan and India (1950) marked an initiation of mutually accepted diplomatic exchange and a pledge to strengthen trade and cultural links. Neither did India seek influence over Kabul's foreign policy as previously sought by the British, nor did it continue the supply of arms to the Afghan Army, as was planned according to a 1945 bilateral agreement. Though training of Afghan officers on Indian soil was permitted, weapons or salaries to these officers were not to be offered.[18] For